

## Shifting Towards Accessible Pedagogy in Humanities Courses: 20 Ideas to Try

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- Reflect on what steps have you already taken or could you take to make your courses accessible. Then review the below list of “20 Ideas to Try” to see if you could do more.
- Aim to make things accessible for both the instructor and students.
- Take a **“Plus 1 Approach”**: for each new course outing, try one new thing to make the course more accessible; then, at the next course outing, try another thing, gradually making your courses more accessible over time.

Accessible pedagogy might include the following pro-active (rather than reactive) activities that consider flexibility, variety, preparation, transparency, choice, and barrier reduction among others.

### GENERAL COURSE DESIGN & DELIVERY

1. add **accessibility information and various student supports/resources** to your course syllabus
2. offer a **synchronous Zoom session** that students can attend from home if they are ill
3. record class meetings and **post recordings on Brightspace** (or make them available upon request)
4. **post lecture notes on Brightspace** (or make them available upon request)
5. **source accessible materials** (e.g., PDFs and .docx versions of texts) that aren't expensive for students

### ASSIGNMENTS

6. design assignments with **“accessibility for all”** in mind (e.g., aim for the “curb-cut effect”: cut curbs were originally designed for wheelchair users but benefit everyone, including people with strollers, luggage, or bikes, etc.)
7. **provide examples and models of past student assignments** to help students better understand expectations
8. offer **multiple ways for students to earn engaged participation marks** (e.g., speaking up during class discussion, writing a discussion post, writing a metacognitive reflection, attending office hours, participating in small group discussions in class, participating in course surveys, etc.)
9. offer **multi-stage distraction-reduced exams** to create a more distraction-reduced environment that may reduce reliance on CAL/OREM (e.g., date 1: first ½ of class writes in-class exam for 50 or 80 minutes while other ½ of class completes at-home work; date 2: second half of class writes in-class exam while

other ½ of class completes at-home work; ask students who will finish early to sit closer to door to reduce distractions when they exit; allow students to use noise-cancelling headphones)

10. offer **universal extended time** (UET) for in-class assignments (e.g., offer 50 minutes for a 25-minute test or 80 minutes for a 40-minutes test)
11. offer students **multiple ways into a topic/text** (e.g., short author video, written text, podcast, song, artwork, book review, guest speaker, guided prompts circulated before lecture so students can focus their thinking, etc.)
12. offer students **multiple ways to demonstrate their learning** (e.g., essay, discussion post, oral interview or exam, short writing exercise, quiz, class presentation, low-stakes and high-stakes versions of assignments, group work, individual work, creative project, unessay, process-oriented assignments, etc.)
13. offer **open-book exams or exam support materials** so exams don't necessarily focus on memory recall (e.g., a list of work titles and authors with nationality and birth/death dates; identify which texts excerpts are from)
14. book a **computer lab for in-class assessments** for students who prefer writing on the computer; you can still allow those who wish to write by hand to do so in the computer lab
15. offer **staggered due dates or due date grace periods** (e.g., due date 1: receives full feedback; due date 2: receives reduced feedback; due date 3: receives grade only)

## FEEDBACK

16. offer **various methods of providing feedback/marking** (e.g., written feedback, Brightspace video or audio feedback, checkbox rubric for smaller assignments)
17. provide **transparent grading rubrics** for all core assignments
18. provide **clear guidelines** on how and when students will be expected to collaborate with one another or engage in group work during class and outside of class
19. provide a **structured worksheet or group contract** where students can assign roles/responsibilities, agree to a check-in schedule, and establish communication expectations
20. offer **anonymous feedback cards or short Brightspace surveys** to hear from students mid-course about what is working well and what isn't